preparing for the Thame sheep fair, one of our most important sales of the year.

Since I had averaged 7.5 in the first two Tests, who needed nets? I worked in an open-air gym, sorting and handling animals rather than lifting dumbbells. I also associate farm duties with my becoming the youngest player to reach 10,000 Test runs, at the age of thirty-one years, five months and five days, on the fourth day of the second Test against Sri Lanka at Chester-le-Street in 2016.

I overhauled Sachin Tendulkar's record with a leg-side clip for four off Nuwan Pradeep, and had a good night after seeing England to a nine-wicket win with an unbeaten 47, because it was something special ticked off my bucket list. Alice's parents were there to see me, and we left early the following morning, with work to do.

When we got home, after a four-hour drive, it was absolutely banging down with rain. The lambs needed to be weighed because there was a lorry booked in to take the lambs that made the desired weight to the abattoir the next day. Chris, Alice's dad, quite rightly didn't fancy going out, so it was left to me and the dog. The weather was horrendous; even the dog was nestling her nose beneath my coat as we took off, on a quad bike, to round up the 150 or so animals destined for market.

Once they were caught, we had to weigh them and load them on to the lorry. The process is automatic because of its familiarity, but I did wonder what the previous day's crowd, and the people watching on television, would have made of me there, soaked to the skin and caked in mud. So much for the halos and hurrahs reserved for the so-called cricket star.

Again, I respect the sensitivities involved, and trust my good faith will be recognized, but my love of both the countryside and the principles of its management has been deepened by my hobby – shooting. It has involved the development of a challenging new skill and is a pursuit that encourages the same sort of friendships and memories that can be found in more mainstream sports.

I am no George Digweed, who is Britain's best shot, having won, at the last count, a ridiculous 26 World Championships, 18 European Championships, 116 International Championships, 16 World Cups, 10 European Cups and 11 English and British Championships. *Wisden* also informs us he took eight wickets without conceding a run in five overs in a